

# ■ ■ Summer Camp Games

Quick-reference card — minimal setup, maximum fun

## ■ Quick-Launch — No Setup Needed

### Caught Peekin'

8–30 players · 5–10 min · Any space

Everyone stands in a circle with their heads down and eyes closed. On 'Go!', everyone looks up and locks eyes with exactly one other person. If you make eye contact with someone who is also looking at you — you're both out! No talking, no pointing. The group gets smaller and smaller until the last two remaining try to stare each other down. Pure social awareness, zero equipment, instant laughter.

### B'gawk!

8–30 players · 10–15 min · Any space

Stand in a circle. One player starts by thrusting their arms forward (like a chicken beak) toward a neighbor and shouting 'B'GAWK!' That neighbor immediately passes it on. You can reverse the direction by flapping your elbows and squawking back. Miss your cue, hesitate too long, or break the rhythm? You're out. The game speeds up as it goes. Absolutely ridiculous — in the best way.

### Fruit Salad

10–40 players · 10–20 min · Open space

Everyone sits in a circle (in chairs or cross-legged spots on the ground). Assign each player a fruit: apple, banana, or mango. The caller stands in the middle and shouts a fruit — all players with that fruit must jump up and scramble to a new spot while the caller tries to steal one. When the caller shouts 'FRUIT SALAD!' — everyone moves at once. Whoever is left without a spot becomes the new caller.

### Evolution

10–40 players · 10–15 min · Any open space

Everyone starts as an egg — crouch low and waddle around. Find another egg and play rock-paper-scissors. The winner evolves to a chicken (stand up, flap arms, cluck). Chickens find chickens to challenge. Win again and you become a dinosaur (stomp and roar). Win as a dinosaur and you become a human (walk tall, cheer). The goal is to evolve to human. The whole group is playing simultaneously — beautiful chaos.

### Gorilla, Person, Pistol

6–40 players · 10–20 min · Open space

Whole-body rock-paper-scissors played in two teams. Gorilla beats Person (gorillas eat people), Person beats Pistol (people use guns), Pistol beats Gorilla (you can shoot a gorilla). Teams huddle secretly, pick their move, then face each other and act it out on the count of three — full dramatic poses. Losing team runs to their safe zone before the winners tag them. Tagged players switch sides. Teams grow and shrink — the game naturally self-balances.

### Five in Ten

5–30 players · 10–20 min · Any space

Split into small teams. The caller shouts a category ('Things you'd find at a beach!' or 'Breakfast foods!') and teams have just 10 seconds to name five things in that category. Teams shout their answers simultaneously — first team to get five wins the round. Categories can get silly fast: 'Things a seagull would steal' or 'Excuses for being late to camp.' No materials needed, endlessly customizable.

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## Group Up

10–40 players · 5–10 min · Large open space

Everyone mills around the open space. When the caller shouts a number, players scramble to form groups of exactly that size — no more, no fewer. Anyone left out sits down. Keep calling numbers, keep playing until only two or three remain. You can also use categories instead of numbers: 'Group up by birth month!' or 'Find everyone wearing the same color!' Great energy-builder at the start of any session.

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## Group Juggle / Warp Speed

8–25 players · 10–15 min · Circle space

Stand in a circle. Establish a throwing pattern — toss a ball to someone across from you, they toss to someone else, never to a neighbor, until everyone has touched it once and it returns to the start. Now try to beat your own time. Now add a second ball going the opposite direction. The magic of this game is that the group competes against themselves — kids get obsessed with beating their record. No losers, pure team focus.

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## ■ Water-Friendly Games

### Drip, Drip, Drench

8–30 players · 10–20 min · Outdoors

Duck Duck Goose — but with water. Everyone sits in a circle. The caller walks around tapping heads and saying 'drip... drip... drip...' and then dumps a full cup of water on someone's head and shouts 'DRENCH!' That person leaps up and chases the caller around the circle. If they make it back to the empty spot safely, the drenched player becomes the new caller. On a hot day, everyone secretly wants to be chosen.

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### Sponge Relay Race

10–40 players · 10–15 min · Outdoors

Split into teams of 5–8. Each team has a bucket of water at one end and an empty bucket at the other. Players soak a large sponge, run it to the empty bucket, squeeze it out, and sprint back to tag the next person. The team that fills their bucket highest in 3 minutes wins. Variation: pass the soaked sponge overhead down a line of players — no running, just squeezing and passing. The last player wrings it into the bucket.

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### Water Balloon Numbers

10–30 players · 10–20 min · Outdoors

Assign every player a number. Players spread out in an open field. The caller (holding a bucket of water balloons) shouts a number — that player runs to the center, grabs a balloon, and tries to tag as many others as possible before it pops. Everyone else sprints away. Once the balloon pops or is thrown, that round ends. Fast, unpredictable, and everyone stays on their toes — even if their number hasn't been called yet.

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### Freeze Tag with Squirt Guns

8–25 players · 15–20 min · Outdoors

Classic freeze tag — but the 'unfreeze' move is a teammate squirting you with a water gun. One or two players are 'it' and try to tag everyone into frozen statues. Frozen players stand with arms out, waiting to be rescued. A free teammate can unfreeze them with a squirt of water. If all players are frozen, the taggers win. Swap 'it' roles every few rounds so everyone gets a turn with the squirt gun.

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## ■ Calm & Transition Games

## Camouflage

6–20 players · 15–25 min · Wooded/naturalistic space

One player is the 'spotter' and stands at a fixed point. They close their eyes and count to 30 while everyone else hides — but here's the twist: you must hide somewhere the spotter can see from their spot without moving their feet. The spotter then scans for players without moving. If they spot someone, they call out the hiding spot and that person is out. Every 30 seconds, the spotter takes one step forward — the hiding spots shrink. Last one unseen wins.

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## Lion's Cub

6–20 players · 10–20 min · Quiet outdoor space

One player is the Lion and sits blindfolded in the center of a circle, guarding a set of keys (or any object) placed right at their feet. The other players creep silently toward the keys, trying to grab them without being heard. If the Lion hears someone moving, they point in that direction — if they point at you, you're frozen for 10 seconds. Successfully stealing the keys without being caught means you become the Lion. Tense, quiet, and weirdly compelling.

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## Cloud Watching

2–30 players · 10–20 min · Outdoors with open sky

Everyone lies on their backs in the grass and looks up. One person points to a cloud and names what shape they see. The group discusses. Then the next person picks a cloud. That's it — and somehow it works every time. This game is gold for slowing a wound-up group down, resetting energy between activities, or filling a peaceful 10-minute gap. Works especially well right after lunch or before a focused session. No losers, no setup, no noise.

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## How Long Is a Minute?

5–40 players · 5–10 min · Any space

Everyone closes their eyes and stands up. When the facilitator says 'Go,' players sit down when they think exactly one minute has passed. No counting, no phones, no peeking — just internal time sense. The facilitator silently notes who sits when. At the end, reveal who sat closest to 60 seconds. Turns out most people have wildly different internal clocks. Works as a settling activity, a mindfulness moment, or just a fun discovery about your own body.

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## Crossed or Uncrossed?

8–30 players · 10–15 min · Seated circle

The facilitator passes an object (a stick, a marker, anything) to the next person and says 'I'm passing this crossed' or 'I'm passing this uncrossed.' The group must figure out the secret rule for what makes it crossed or uncrossed — but it has nothing to do with the object itself. The trick: it's about whether your ankles (or arms) are crossed when you pass it. Players who figure it out play along secretly, keeping the magic alive for those still guessing. A wonderful slow-burn mystery.

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*Tip: Laminate and keep in your bag — you'll thank yourself at 11:58am before lunch.*